of Bharat', nominally referring to a legendary king from the *R-V* named Bharata but a word that can equally be read as 'the continent maintained by fire', suggesting the clearance of the jungle by the most basic form of farming – slash-and-burn. The hymns of the *Atharva-Veda*, the last of the four Vedas, reflects this settling-down process. Most of its hymns are a mix of flattery directed at one or other of the deities, coupled with demands for divine help, often in the form of spells and invocations.

Nowhere is this combination of flattery and demand more apparent than in the best known of all the hymns of the *Atharva-Veda*: Book 12, known as the *Prithvi Sukta*, in which the composer heaps praise on the earth-goddess Prithvi but also calls on her to give to the new settlers all that she has to offer. The *Prithvi Sukta* is frequently cited as the earliest example of human environmental responsibility, but modern translations seem to have moved a long way from the first renderings of the *Prithvi Sukta* into English by the industrious Sanskritist Ralph Griffith.[24] Griffith's translation of the *Prithvi Sukta* makes it clear that the Arya are asking the earth to work for them – as, for example, in Verse 4:

> *She who is Lady of the earth's four regions, in whom our food and our corn-lands had their being,*
> *Nurse in each place of living, moving creatures, this Earth, vouchsafe us kine [cattle] with milk that fails not.*[25]

So it goes on. But Prithvi is also called upon again and again to give the Arya protection from their foes, more specifically those known collectively to the Arya as Dasas or Dasyus, described as the 'God-blaspheming Dasyus … on whom the men of old before us battled'.

The numerous references in the Vedas to these same Dasas as demonic enemies to be fought and subdued suggest that the Arya occupation of the land was by no